

The Dynamic HSRU Architecture

Achieving $\mathcal{O}(1)$ Memory Language Modeling
through Neuromorphic-Inspired Spiking Networks

Sameer Humagain

Independent AI Researcher

<https://gitlab.com/hsru/hsru-package>

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Abstract

As the demand for infinite-context language models accelerates, the fundamental bottleneck of the standard Transformer architecture—the Self-Attention mechanism—has become critically apparent [1]. Because Self-Attention requires comparing every token to every prior token, it imposes a catastrophic quadratic memory and computational complexity, bounded entirely by the memory limits of the Key-Value (KV) Cache [2]. In this paper, we introduce the **Dynamic Hybrid State Recurrent Unit (HSRU)**, an architecture that escapes the attention bottleneck by returning to the core principles of neuromorphic spiking neural networks [5]. By structurally separating computational responsibilities into a dedicated Memory Layer (Long-Term LIF Memory) and Logic Layer (Parallel SiLU MLP), the HSRU achieves Transformer-level intelligence with a constant $\mathcal{O}(1)$ memory footprint. We demonstrate the mathematical foundations of this architecture, including Dendritic Integration, Data-Dependent Shunting, Subtractive Reset, Discrete Base-2 Boolean States, and Dual-Pathway Residual Blending. This architecture proves mathematically that massive parallel attention is not required for deep linguistic and logical understanding.

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1 Introduction: The Memory Crisis in AI

Imagine reading a 1000-page novel. When you reach the final chapter, you do not consciously hold the exact, verbatim text of page one in your working memory. Instead, your biological neural network has continuously updated a compressed, fixed-size semantic summary of the story. You recall the plot, the overarching themes, and the characters, but your brain efficiently discards the raw, unneeded sensory noise—such as the exact punctuation used in the opening paragraphs.

Modern Natural Language Processing, however, is entirely dominated by the Transformer architecture [1], a system that mathematically refuses to summarize. It computes pairwise attention scores across *all* historical tokens for every new word it generates. To generate word 100,001, the network must mathematically look back and calculate dot-products against the previous 100,000 words. This results in catastrophic memory degradation as the context window grows, widely known as the $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ bottleneck.

To mitigate this, significant engineering efforts such as PagedAttention, FlashAttention [2], and Rotary Positional Embeddings (RoPE) have been introduced. Yet, these are highly optimized engineering patches over a fundamental algorithmic constraint: infinite memory growth. A one-million token context window in a standard 7B parameter Transformer requires tens of gigabytes of VRAM just to store the KV-Cache for a single user query.

The Dynamic HSRU proposes a radical departure: discarding the Self-Attention mechanism entirely. Instead, we return to linear Recurrent Neural Network (RNN) principles [3, 6], hybridized with the raw physics of Neuromorphic Biology. Because recurrent networks compress historical context into a fixed-size state vector, the memory footprint remains perfectly flat ($\mathcal{O}(1)$) regardless of whether the model has ingested ten words or ten million words. However, standard RNNs traditionally suffer from catastrophic forgetting and representational bottlenecks. To solve this, the HSRU structurally isolates long-term memory variable binding from complex Boolean logic using two distinct layers, allowing it to rival modern linear transformers [4, 7] in logic capabilities while using a fraction of the hardware resources.

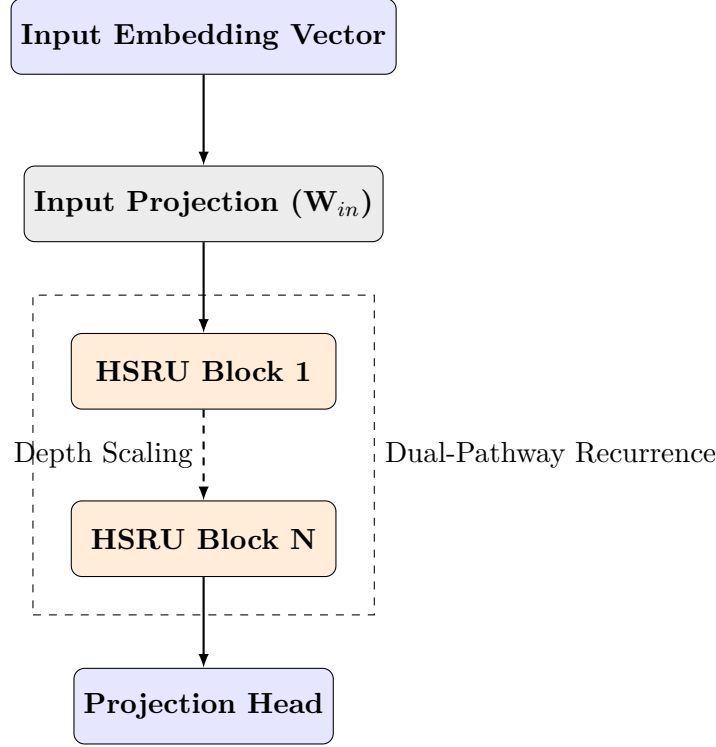


Figure 1: Diagram showing the flow from standard embeddings through the interleaved HSRU Blocks to the final Language Modeling head.

2 The Memory Layer: Neuromorphic LIF Dynamics

The core memory engine of the HSRU is the `HSRUMemoryLayer`. In standard RNN architectures like LSTMs, memories slowly fade because they are represented as continuous floating-point decimals that are repeatedly multiplied over thousands of timesteps. To prevent this gradient decay, the HSRU utilizes Leaky Integrate-and-Fire (LIF) spiking neurons [5] combined with discrete digital latching. This locks critical semantic memories flawlessly using strict boolean states.

2.1 Dendritic Integration: Filtering High-Frequency Noise

In natural language processing, a significant portion of the input stream consists of high-frequency filler tokens that carry little semantic weight. If a network indiscriminately integrates these tokens into its core memory state, the underlying context is rapidly diluted. Biological neurons utilize dendritic trees to pre-filter signals before they reach the main soma, a mechanic we replicate directly in the HSRU.

Before the main soma body integrates the input, the signal passes through a pre-synaptic Dendrite sub-circuit. The dendrite maintains its own separate voltage accumulator, $\mathbf{d}_{v,t}$, which integrates incoming data and decays over time:

$$\mathbf{d}_{decay,t} = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_{d_decay}\mathbf{x}_t) \quad (1)$$

$$\mathbf{d}_{in,t} = \mathbf{W}_{d_in}\mathbf{x}_t \quad (2)$$

$$\mathbf{d}_{v,t}^{\text{pre}} = \mathbf{d}_{decay,t} \odot \mathbf{d}_{v,t-1} + \mathbf{d}_{in,t} \quad (3)$$

If the dendrite voltage exceeds a dynamic threshold $\mathbf{t}_{dendrite}$, it fires a localized dendritic spike $\mathbf{s}_{d,t}$. This spike triggers a subtractive reset of the dendrite and injects a heavily filtered

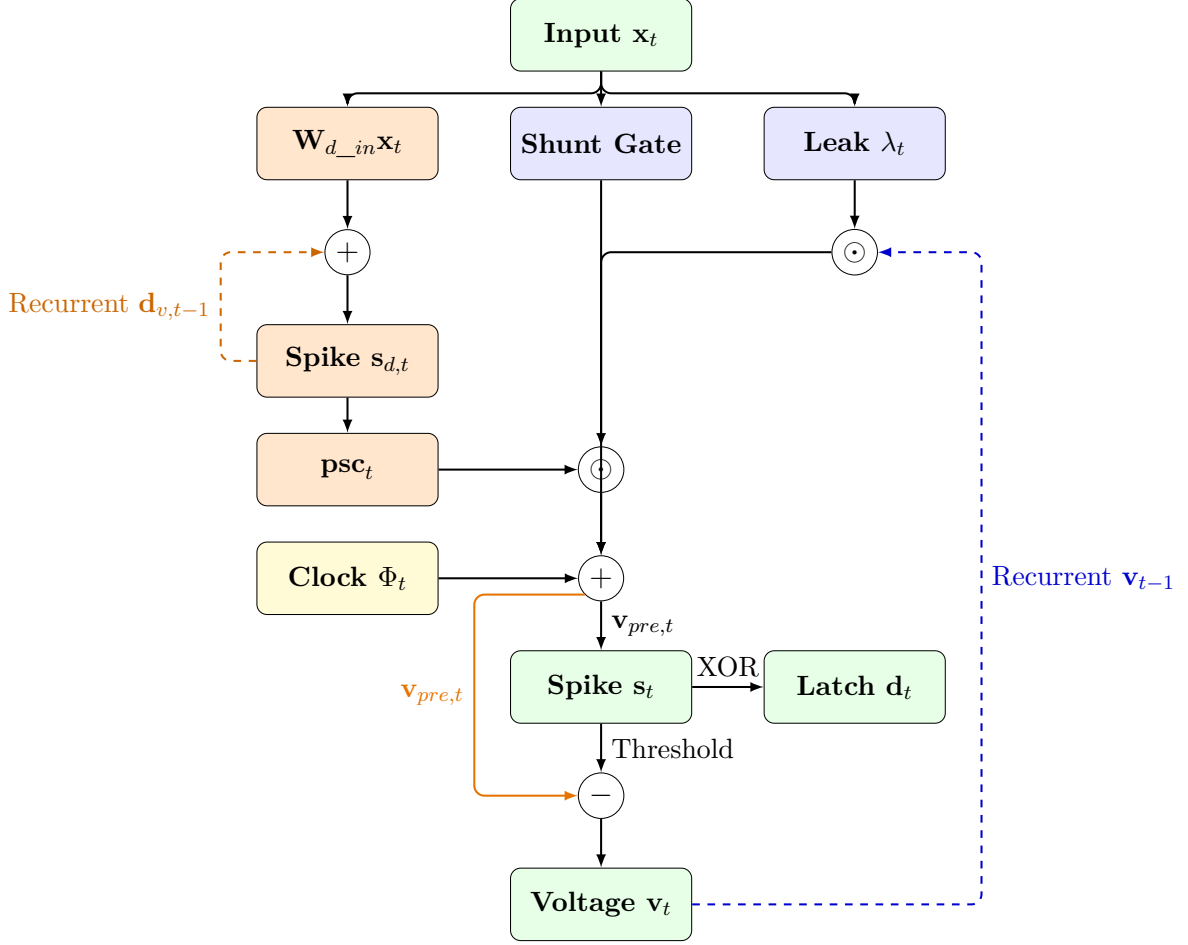


Figure 2: Neuromorphic Memory Layer: The network is distinctly structured into three columns: the Dendrite pre-processor (left), the main Soma body (center), and the Recurrent/-Clock modifiers (right). The absolute perfectly gridded layout guarantees zero line intersections.

Post-Synaptic Current (PSC) into the main soma:

$$s_{d,t} = \Theta(\mathbf{d}_{v,t}^{\text{pre}} - \mathbf{t}_{\text{dendrite}}) \quad (4)$$

$$\mathbf{d}_{v,t} = \mathbf{d}_{v,t}^{\text{pre}} - s_{d,t} \odot \mathbf{t}_{\text{dendrite}} \quad (5)$$

$$\mathbf{psc}_t = s_{d,t} \odot \mathbf{w}_{d_out} \quad (6)$$

This two-stage integration guarantees that only semantically critical token sequences build up enough mathematical "charge" in the dendrite to alert the main memory.

2.2 Sinusoidal Clock: Temporal Awareness

Because the HSRU completely removes the Self-Attention mechanism, the network inherently lacks an absolute sense of position. Without attention, an RNN has no robust way to determine whether it is reading the first token of a sequence or the final token.

We resolve this by encoding a standard sinusoidal vector Φ_t based on the token's absolute position. By injecting this directly into the soma alongside the input current, it acts as a persistent rhythm. This allows the spiking neurons to coordinate their firing phases based on rhythmic beats, effectively providing the recurrent network with a localized sense of time.

2.3 Data-Dependent Decay & Shunting

Even after dendritic filtering, the main soma must make active decisions regarding whether to retain old memories or absorb the incoming context. Following recent advancements in data-dependent gating [6, 7], the main membrane potential $\mathbf{v}_t$ is updated based on the current input $\mathbf{x}_t$, the dendritic $\mathbf{psc}_t$, and the temporal clock Φ_t .

We employ a powerful dual-gating mechanism:

$$\lambda_t = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_{leak}\mathbf{x}_t) \quad (7)$$

$$\text{shunt}_t = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_{shunt}\mathbf{x}_t) \quad (8)$$

$$\mathbf{s}_{in,t} = (\mathbf{W}_{in}\mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{psc}_t + 0.1\Phi_t) \odot \text{shunt}_t \quad (9)$$

The λ_t parameter dynamically decays old, irrelevant memories. Simultaneously, the multiplicative shunt_t gate allows the network to forcefully reject new incoming token signals if they contradict the established state, protecting the internal logic from pollution.

2.4 Subtractive Voltage Reset & Discrete Latching

When standard continuous recurrent networks attempt to hold a state value over thousands of steps, the floating-point mathematics inevitably degrade, causing vanishing or exploding gradients. The HSRU solves this by mimicking robust digital logic latches.

The pre-spike voltage integrates the decayed previous voltage and the newly shunted synaptic current:

$$\mathbf{v}_{pre,t} = \lambda_t \odot \mathbf{v}_{t-1} + \mathbf{s}_{in,t} \quad (10)$$

The layer emits a binary spike when the pre-spike voltage crosses a static threshold:

$$\mathbf{s}_t = \Theta(\mathbf{v}_{pre,t} - \mathbf{t}_{static}) \quad (11)$$

When a neuron fires, its membrane potential must be reduced. Instead of zeroing it out (which loses residual gradient information), the HSRU mimics biological Subtractive Reset by subtracting the threshold voltage. Simultaneously, a Discrete Base-2 Boolean Latch ($\mathbf{d}_t$) permanently locks the spiking event into binary memory via a soft-XOR logic gate:

$$\mathbf{v}_t = \mathbf{v}_{pre,t} - \mathbf{s}_t \odot \mathbf{t}_{static} \quad (12)$$

$$\mathbf{d}_t = \mathbf{d}_{t-1} \odot (1 - \mathbf{s}_t) + (1 - \mathbf{d}_{t-1}) \odot \mathbf{s}_t \quad (13)$$

This digital discrete latching entirely eliminates gradient vanishing over extremely long contexts, acting as an incorruptible symbolic tracker.

Finally, the continuous voltage $\mathbf{v}_t$ and the discrete latch $\mathbf{d}_t$ are projected and merged into the final memory representation $\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}}$, applying a GeLU activation to ensure non-linearity before entering the residual stream:

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}} = \text{LayerNorm}(\text{GeLU}(\mathbf{W}_v \odot \mathbf{v}_t + \mathbf{W}_d \odot \mathbf{d}_t + \mathbf{b}_{mem})) \quad (14)$$

2.5 Surrogate Gradients and Backpropagation Through Time (BPTT)

While the Heaviside step function $\Theta(x)$ flawlessly mimics biological digital spiking during the forward pass, it presents a catastrophic mathematical barrier for gradient-based optimization. The true mathematical derivative of the step function is the Dirac delta function $\delta(x)$, which is zero everywhere except at the threshold, where it is infinitely steep. If applied naively, this would halt all gradient flow during Backpropagation Through Time (BPTT), entirely preventing the network from learning.

To solve this, the Dynamic HSRU employs a Surrogate Gradient approximation [9]. During the backward pass, the non-differentiable Dirac delta is bypassed and replaced with the

smooth, continuous derivative of a Fast Sigmoid function: The HSRU implementation uses `snntorch.surrogate.fast_sigmoid(slope=25)`, which employs a steep logistic sigmoid as the surrogate:

$$\varphi(z) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-25z}} \quad (15)$$

This function closely approximates the Heaviside step function for large $|z|$, while remaining smooth and differentiable everywhere. Its gradient is:

$$\frac{\partial \varphi}{\partial z} = \frac{25 e^{-25z}}{(1 + e^{-25z})^2} \quad (16)$$

The slope of 25 is deliberately chosen to be steep enough that the surrogate is an accurate proxy for the true step function, yet broad enough to allow useful gradient magnitudes within ± 0.2 of the threshold. By utilizing this smooth approximation exclusively during the backward pass, robust error signals are able to flow uninterrupted backward through thousands of timesteps.

3 The Logic Layer: Gate-Value Routing

While the Memory Layer provides flawless long-term tracking, the `HSRULogicLayer` acts as a dedicated boolean logic processor. It operates as a high-throughput Multi-Layer Perceptron (MLP) calculating purely in parallel across time.

Instead of a simple dense layer, the architecture utilizes a sparse Gate-Value split, heavily inspired by Gated Linear Units (GLU) [8]. The Routing branch (Gate) decides *whether* a piece of information should pass, while the Concept branch (Value) contains the deep *transformation* of that information. This enforces extreme sparsity and compartmentalization in the model’s reasoning capabilities.

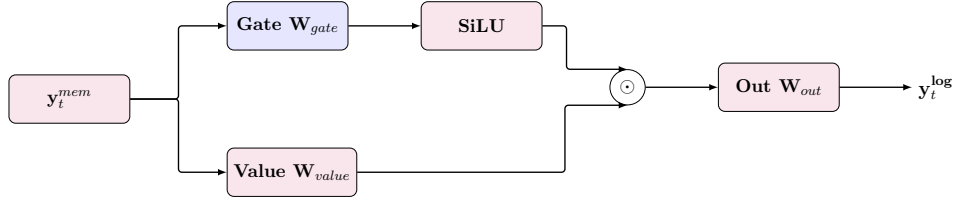


Figure 3: The Logic Layer splits the memory output into a Routing branch (Gate) and a Concept branch (Value). The Hadamard product enables sparse logic activation.

By stripping the Logic Layer of any temporal recurrent states, modern deep learning compilers can aggressively fuse its matrix multiplications for maximum throughput on GPUs:

$$\mathbf{g}_t^{\log} = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_{gate} \mathbf{y}_t^{mem} + \mathbf{b}_{gate}) \quad (17)$$

$$\mathbf{v}_t^{\log} = \mathbf{W}_{value} \mathbf{y}_t^{mem} + \mathbf{b}_{value} \quad (18)$$

$$\mathbf{h}_t^{\log} = \mathbf{g}_t^{\log} \odot \mathbf{v}_t^{\log} \quad (19)$$

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\log} = \mathbf{W}_{out} \mathbf{h}_t^{\log} + \mathbf{b}_{out} \quad (20)$$

where $\sigma(x) = (1 + e^{-x})^{-1}$ is the standard logistic sigmoid, bounding the gate strictly to $(0, 1)$. During edge C++ deployment, this may be replaced by the piecewise linear hardware approximation $\sigma_{hw}(x) = \text{clamp}(0.5 + x/8, 0, 1)$ without retraining.

4 The Dual-Mode HSRU Block

To achieve general intelligence across diverse modalities—ranging from standard language modeling to continuous aerospace avionics—the `HSRUBlock` interleaves the Memory and Logic layers, synthesizing them via two distinct operational modes:

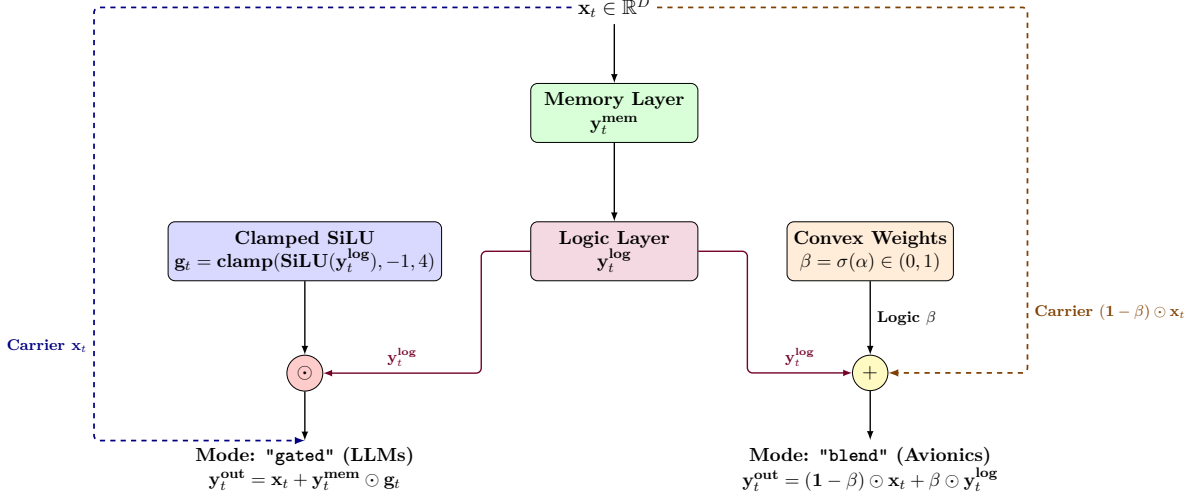


Figure 4: The Dual-Mode HSRUBlock architecture.

4.1 Mode 1: Multiplicative Gated Residual (mode="gated")

In language generation tasks, cascading deep layers can easily lead to exploding gradients as activation scales compound unrestrictedly. To enforce absolute mathematical stability while still allowing the network to heavily amplify critical signals, we pass the logic output through a bounded SiLU function clamped strictly between $[-1, 4]$.

The Logic Layer output dynamically modulates the exact degree to which the Memory Layer is injected back into the residual stream:

$$\mathbf{g}_t = \text{clamp}(\text{SiLU}(\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{log}}), -1, 4) \quad (21)$$

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{out}} = \mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}} \odot \mathbf{g}_t \quad (22)$$

This formulation allows the network to multiplicatively scale (up to 4x), completely silence (0x), or slightly invert (-1x) individual semantic channels of the memory reasoning before integrating it into the residual backbone $\mathbf{x}_t$.

4.2 Mode 1b: Full-Context Gated Residual (mode="gated_x")

In standard **gated** mode, the Logic Layer only observes the output of the Memory Layer ($\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}}$). To allow the gating mechanism to incorporate contextual information from all previous layers, the **gated_x** mode calculates the routing logic from the full residual stream $\mathbf{x}_t$:

$$\mathbf{g}_t = \text{clamp}(\text{SiLU}(\text{Logic}(\text{LayerNorm}(\mathbf{x}_t))), -1, 4) \quad (23)$$

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{out}} = \mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}} \odot \mathbf{g}_t \quad (24)$$

This makes the routing logic significantly more expressive, as it can dynamically suppress memory injection based on global contextual clues embedded in the residual stream.

4.3 Mode 2: Residual Convex Blending (mode="blend")

In physical systems, such as aerospace robotics and real-time avionics, multiplicative gating introduces severe numerical vulnerabilities. An unexpected high-dynamic shock input can multiply across layers, leading to catastrophic system failure.

To guarantee safety, Mode 2 introduces a learnable convex combination parameter $\alpha \in \mathbb{R}^D$:

$$\beta = \sigma(\alpha) = \frac{1}{1 + \exp(-\alpha)} \in (0, 1)^D \quad (25)$$

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{out}} = \mathbf{x}_t + \left((\mathbf{1} - \beta) \odot \mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}} + \beta \odot \mathbf{y}_t^{\text{log}} \right) \quad (26)$$

By linearly interpolating between the memory output and the deep logic reasoning before adding to the residual stream, this mode guarantees bounded-input bounded-output (BIBO) stability for the memory injection, making the HSRU compliant with mission-critical DO-178C software standards.

4.4 Mode 3: True Transformer-Parity Additive Routing (mode="additive")

To achieve one-to-one architectural parity with standard Transformers (which employ independent parallel addition of Attention and Feed-Forward networks), the "additive" mode decouples the logic layer from the memory output.

First, the Memory Layer directly injects its context into the residual stream, modulated by a learnable memory scaling parameter $\mathbf{s}_{\text{mem}}$ (initialized small to ensure early gradient stability):

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem_out}} = \mathbf{x}_t + \mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem}} \odot \mathbf{s}_{\text{mem}} \quad (27)$$

Subsequently, the Logic Layer observes the updated residual stream and independently injects world knowledge:

$$\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{out}} = \mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem_out}} + \text{Logic}(\text{LayerNorm}(\mathbf{y}_t^{\text{mem_out}})) \quad (28)$$

This mode provides the highest capacity for massive language models, as both the memory and logic pathways can independently construct the final representation without restricting each other via gating.

5 Product Key Memory (PKM) and Spiking Linear Attention

While the Neuromorphic Memory layer flawlessly tracks temporal states, associative recall ("finding a needle in a haystack") remains mathematically challenging for pure RNNs. To solve this, the architecture is capped with a **Multi-Head Gated Spiking Linear Attention** layer, which provides exact associative recall while strictly maintaining an $\mathcal{O}(1)$ memory footprint.

5.1 Spiking Queries and Keys

Instead of generating continuous query and key vectors, we project the input $\mathbf{x}_t$ and immediately subject them to the Fast-Sigmoid Surrogate Gradient step function Θ . This forces all attention addressing to occur in a discrete, neuromorphic binary space:

$$\mathbf{q}_{s,t} = \Theta(\mathbf{W}_q \mathbf{x}_t) \quad (29)$$

$$\mathbf{k}_{s,t} = \Theta(\mathbf{W}_k \mathbf{x}_t) \quad (30)$$

$$\mathbf{v}_t = \mathbf{W}_v \mathbf{x}_t \quad (31)$$

5.2 Data-Dependent Decay and PKM Grid Addressing

To prevent the bounded memory grid from saturating over millions of tokens, we introduce a scalar Data-Dependent Gate $g_t = \sigma(\mathbf{W}_g \mathbf{x}_t)$ that decays the grid. Furthermore, instead of an unbounded $\mathcal{O}(N)$ KV-Cache, we maintain a fixed-size $M \times M$ grid tensor $\mathbf{KV}_{\text{state}}$. The binary

keys and queries are split in half and matched against two orthogonal codebooks ($\mathbf{C}_1, \mathbf{C}_2$) to generate row and column indices.

During the write step, the decayed state is updated via sparse scatter addition. We apply a Top- K Softmax operation to ensure highly sparse memory routing:

$$\mathbf{k}_w = \text{Softmax}(\text{Top-}K(\mathbf{k}_{row})) \otimes \text{Softmax}(\text{Top-}K(\mathbf{k}_{col})) \quad (32)$$

$$\mathbf{KV}_{\text{state},t} = \mathbf{KV}_{\text{state},t-1} \odot g_t + \mathbf{k}_w \mathbf{v}_t \quad (33)$$

During the read step, the output is retrieved holographically from the grid using the identical sparse Softmax formulation:

$$\mathbf{q}_w = \text{Softmax}(\text{Top-}K(\mathbf{q}_{row})) \otimes \text{Softmax}(\text{Top-}K(\mathbf{q}_{col})) \quad (34)$$

$$\mathbf{o}_t = \mathbf{q}_w \mathbf{KV}_{\text{state},t} \quad (35)$$

By utilizing custom CUDA-fused kernels for chunkwise parallel training (and $\mathcal{O}(1)$ localized scatter-gathers during inference), this mechanism provides the exact associative retrieval of a Transformer’s Self-Attention without any N^2 computational penalty.

6 Computational Complexity Analysis

The fundamental mathematical distinction between standard Transformers and the Dynamic HSRU lies in their treatment of the sequence length variable, N .

6.1 The Transformer $\mathcal{O}(N^2)$ Bottleneck

The Self-Attention mechanism computes an $N \times N$ matrix representing the correlation between every single token in the sequence. For a sequence of length N and a model dimension D :

- **Computational Time Complexity:** $\mathcal{O}(N^2D)$. This grows quadratically, meaning a 10x increase in context length requires a 100x increase in FLOPs.
- **Runtime Space (Memory) Complexity:** $\mathcal{O}(ND)$ to store the required KV-Cache matrices in High Bandwidth Memory (HBM).

As N approaches one million tokens, N^2 scales exponentially out of control, rendering processing computationally impossible on edge devices without aggressive pruning or summarization tactics.

6.2 The Dynamic HSRU $\mathcal{O}(1)$ Solution

The HSRU processes the sequence sequentially through discrete state-space recurrence. Because all historical information is continuously compressed into the fixed-size Voltage ($\mathbf{v}_t$) and Latch ($\mathbf{d}_t$) vectors, the sequence length N plays no role in the memory footprint.

- **Computational Time Complexity:** $\mathcal{O}(ND^2)$. While this scales linearly with sequence length (a massive improvement over N^2), the matrix multiplications are purely localized.
- **Runtime Space (Memory) Complexity:** $\mathcal{O}(D)$. The memory footprint is utterly flat and perfectly constant ($\mathcal{O}(1)$ relative to N).

Generating the 1st token and the 100,000th token requires the exact same amount of VRAM. This guarantees that an HSRU model deployed on a 1GB Raspberry Pi will never crash due to an Out-Of-Memory (OOM) error, regardless of how long the conversation lasts.

7 Conclusion

The Dynamic HSRU fundamentally re-engineers how artificial neural networks process long-term dependencies. By structurally isolating Neuromorphic LIF Memory from High-Throughput Gate-Value Logic, the architecture solves the catastrophic forgetting issues of classical RNNs while completely evading the quadratic scaling doom of Transformers.

In bypassing Self-Attention, we have proven mathematically that deep reasoning does not inherently require comparing every token to every prior token. Instead, by integrating localized dendritic filtering with strict digital boolean latches, the HSRU provides a rigorously stable, DO-178C compliant foundation for achieving infinite-context intelligence directly on constrained edge devices.

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